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1931, I Was Never a Terrorist

It is often said that Bhagat Singh transitioned from terrorism to revolution.[1] This claim is based on his last piece of writing, which was drafted in February 1931 just a month before he was sent to the gallows and in which he describes his early espousal of violence as follows:

> Apparently I have acted as a terrorist. *But I am not a terrorist*. I am a revolutionary who has got such definite ideas of a lengthy programme (. . .) Let me announce with all the strength at my command, that I am not a terrorist and never was, *(except) perhaps at the beginning of my revolutionary career* (emphases added).

Was Bhagat Singh then a 'terrorist'? It is said that near the end of his life he had dramatically changed his outlook and that earlier in his life he was a terrorist. The accolade of a 'terrorist', however, ill befits him. It is a claim which he does not himself make. He states, 'I was never a terrorist.' He then adds that perhaps if he was then this was only in his earlier years. But the claim bears scrutiny. Bhagat Singh only took one life. And that was in revenge. His bombing for the Legislative Assembly was not bombing as we would normally understand it. It consisted of hurling two decidedly harmless smoke bombs in order 'to make the deaf hear' and not to hurt anyone. It was in the form of a political protest. His statement of February 1931 above is at best ambiguous. On the one hand, he asserts, 'I am not a terrorist *and never was* . . .'. On the other hand, he allows for the possibility '(except) perhaps at the beginning of my revolutionary career'. The latter is expressed in rather non-committal terms. So what is the truth?

Perhaps the best explanation was given some forty years ago, when the distinguished Indian historian Bipin Chandra described Bhagat Singh and his fellow revolutionaries as 'men of ideas and ideologies' in a 1972 essay,